Revisiting Geopolitical Alignment: Political and Economic Implications

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November 12, 2026

PRELIMINARY DRAFT - DO NOT CIRCULATE

Abstract

In a multipolar global order, properly measuring countries' geopolitical alignment is an important research objective. While using UNGA voting patterns as a proxy for alignment is well established in the literature, I posit that bilateral geopolitical distance does not take into account the reciprocal nature of international relations. I employ a refined measurement that sheds new light on geopolitical reciprocity, hegemons' alignment and geoconomic vulnerability.

1 Introduction

The United Nations were founded in the aftermath of World War II, its main goal being the development of a new international order based on collegiality and representation of all nations.[1] At the core of the UN lies its General Assembly, where votes on non-binding resolutions allow countries to signal their position on international issues such as conflicts or humanitarian crises. Researchers in International Relations have worked a number of statistical procedures to analyse patterns of UNGA voting.[2] The most successful development in this field has been Bailey, Strezhnev, and Voeten 2017, wherein the authors employ a spatial ordinal model and compute a distribution of countries' ideal points by year. By taking the Ideal Point Distance (henceforth IPD) between any pair of countries, researchers can use these ideal point estimates to proxy for the geopolitical distance between countries. In the nascent field of Geoeconomics, IPD has been used in relation to the impact it might have on economic relations between countries, such as trade flows and FDI. [3] Another relevant application has consisted in estimating countries' relative geoeconomic positioning. In this particular framework, the discussion has focused on the emergence of connector

[1] Not all countries are admitted in the UN and, especially at its 1945 inception, it was a fairly exclusive organisation. See e.g. Hanhimäki 2015 and Luard 1982.

[2] See Bailey, Strezhnev, and Voeten 2017's discussion of the UN voting data literature.

[3] See Gopinath et al. 2025

countries.[4]
This paper aims at showing that the current use of IPD is conceptually flawed, proposes an alternative methodology that provides new perspectives on Geoeconomics. The contribution of this paper is threefold. I propose a quantitative assessment of countries' geopolitical alignment during the Cold War and the current China-USA hegemonic rivalry. The second contribution is showing that current measure of Geoeconomic Vulnerability (GeoV) are not consistent across time and lead to erroneous interpretations that can be remedied by integrating my proposed measure. Third, a new empirical puzzle on the relationship between geopolitical reciprocity and trade is introduced.

2 Data

To measure geopolitical distance, I use data from Bailey, Strezhnev, and Voeten 2017. My attention focuses on the following countries: Great Britain, Türkyie, France, India and Yugoslavia. The choice of this sample is justified by the fact that these countries have played heterogeneous roles in their strategic choices vis à vis the USA and USSR. Such differences, which will be discussed in depth in the results, are instrumental in understanding the nuances captured by the new measure here proposed. For data on International Trade, I integrate the historical dataset from Fouquin and Hugot 2016, with USSR and Yugoslavia data from Campos, Heid, and Timini 2024, and Gaulier and Zignago 2010.

3 Literature Review

A first strand of literature examines the measurement of geopolitical preferences and international alignment through voting behaviour in the UNGA. Among the most influential contributions, Bailey, Strezhnev, and Voeten 2017 develop a dynamic spatial ordinal model to estimate countries' ideal points over time, providing a systematic framework for measuring political preferences and their evolution over time. The resulting ideal points have subsequently been used to construct bilateral measures of geopolitical distance, generally interpreted as proxies for the degree of political affinity between countries. More broadly, the literature has employed treaty commitments and international agreements as alternative indicators of international alignment Simmons and Hopkins 2005; Lupu 2013; Broner, Martin, Meyer, Trebesch, and Zhou Wu 2025. Recent contributions have also explored the relationship between geopolitical alignment and the structure of the international economic order, emphasizing how shifts in global hegemony and political preferences shape international integration Broner, Martin, Meyer, and Trebesch 2025; Broner, Martin, Meyer, Trebesch, and Zhou Wu 2025. Despite these advances, existing approaches largely conceptualize geopolitical alignment through the distance between countries' political

[4] See Aiyar and Ohnsorge 2024, Airaudo et al. 2025, Baur et al. 2025.

preferences, leaving open the question of whether such measures adequately capture the reciprocal nature of bilateral geopolitical relationships.

A second strand of literature investigates the economic consequences of geopolitical alignment and the emergence of geoeconomic fragmentation. Recent research documents how geopolitical tensions increasingly influence international trade patterns, investment decisions, and the organization of global value chains. Gopinath et al. 2025 examine changes in global economic linkages and the extent to which trade relationships are becoming increasingly structured along geopolitical lines. Similarly, Bonadio et al. 2024 quantify the potential economic consequences of decoupling between geopolitical blocs, while Campos, Heid, and Timini 2024 provide historical evidence on the trade consequences of geopolitical fragmentation during the Cold War. From a broader theoretical perspective, Clayton, Maggiori, and Schreger 2024 emphasize how economic interdependence can become a source of geopolitical leverage, as dominant countries may exploit asymmetric trade and financial relationships to pursue strategic objectives. This mechanism is closely related to the concept of geoeconomic vulnerability, whereby countries' dependence on specific economic partners may expose them to geopolitical pressure. In this context, Aiyar and Ohnsorge 2024 investigate the emergence of connector countries, while Baur et al. 2025 analyse the role of non-aligned economies in mitigating the welfare costs of fragmentation. These contributions highlight the importance of understanding how geopolitical positioning translates into economic exposure, although the measurement of such exposure remains closely connected to the underlying definition of geopolitical alignment.

Finally, an important methodological issue concerns how geopolitical distance is constructed and interpreted in empirical applications. The use of ideal point distances implicitly assumes that the relative position of two countries in a common ideological space provides a sufficient representation of their bilateral geopolitical relationship. However, distance is inherently symmetric: the ideological distance between country i and country j is identical to that between j and i. This property may obscure relevant asymmetries in international relations, particularly when countries occupy different positions in the global distribution of political power. The literature on geoeconomic fragmentation increasingly emphasizes the importance of these asymmetric relationships, particularly in the context of hegemonic competition and economic coercion Clayton, Maggiori, and Schreger 2024; Broner, Martin, Meyer, and Trebesch 2025. Moreover, alternative approaches to measuring geopolitical distance and alignment continue to be debated, as illustrated by Airaudo et al. 2025. This paper contributes to this debate by questioning whether conventional ideal point distances adequately capture bilateral geopolitical alignment and by introducing an explicit measue of reciprocity. It then investigates the implications of this distinction for the measurement of geoeconomic vulnerability and for the empirical relationship between geopolitical alignment and bilateral trade.

4 Empirics

4.1 Alignment Measurements

Assuming competition between two hegemons, a natural question is how equidistant other countries are from these two powers. Airaudo et al. 2025 propose the following measure: given a country i and two poles j and k in year t,

$$seg_{ijkt} = \frac{IPD_{ikt} - IPD_{ijt}}{IPD_{ijt} + IPD_{ikt}}. \tag{1}$$

Here, IPD_{ijt} denotes the Ideal Point Distance between countries i and j, estimated by Bailey, Strezhnev, and Voeten 2017 using UNGA voting data.

By construction, seg_{ijkt} is bounded between -1 and 1. A value of 1 indicates that country i is perfectly aligned with country j, whereas a value of -1 indicates perfect alignment with country k. A value of zero implies that the i is equidistant from j and k.

Despite its conceptual appeal and straightforward interpretation, seg_{ijkt} has several shortcomings as an indicator:

- It only indicates whether country i is equally distant from hegemons j and k, but does not establish whether i is actually close to either of them.
- Changes in the coefficient may reflect changes in the absolute distance from one pole, even if the distance from the other remains approximately constant. Such changes may therefore reflect movements in the ideal points of the hegemons themselves rather than a genuine shift in the relative geopolitical positioning of country i.
- It does not account for the relative position of other countries with respect to j and k. In other words, it is insensitive to the distribution of ideal points in a given year.
- In a geopolitical context involving more than two hegemons, it is not possible to compute a meaningful measure of equidistance using one-dimensional data such as ideal points.

I therefore propose an alternative measure, constructed as follows:

- Given a hegemon j and a country i in year t, compute IPD_{ijt} for all countries $i \neq j$ voting in the UNGA in year t.
- Rank countries in descending order of IPD_{ijt}, assigning a rank of 1 to the country that is geopolitically furthest from hegemon j, a rank of 2 to the second furthest, and so on.
- Dividing each country $i's$ ranking by the total number of countries voting in the UNGA in year t.

The resulting measure, which I call the Alignment Percentile (AP_{jit} henceforth), addresses several of the shortcomings of seg_{ijkt}. In particular, it captures a country's relative geopolitical position within the distribution of UNGA voting patterns in a given year. A higher AP_{ji} (resp. lower) indicates greater relative geopolitical proximity of i to the hegemon j.

I illustrate the properties of this new measure by comparing it with the conventional Alignment Index. I choose two prominent examples of geopolitical rivalry: the USA–USSR competition during the Cold War and the contemporary USA-China rivalry. In particular, I compute

$$HI_{ijkt} = \frac{AP_{jit} - AP_{kit}}{AP_{jit} + AP_{kit}}.$$

HI_{ijkt} is, by construction, bounded in the interval $[-1; 1]$. A value of 1 (resp.-1) implies perfect alignment with respect to j (resp. k).

4.1.1 Cold War

In this section, I examine the alignment behaviour of five countries over the course of the Cold War: Türkiye, Great Britain, India, France and Yugoslavia. The rationale behind this selection is to compare countries with different geopolitical orientations and identify common patterns and divergences in their voting behaviour.

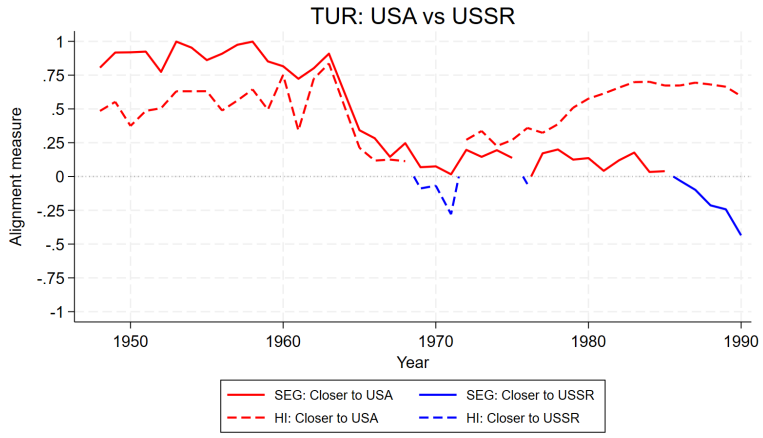


Figure 1: Türkiye: HI vs SEG during the Cold War.

Türkiye is often mentioned as a paradigmatic example of a middle power.[5] According to the Alignment Index time series, the beginning of Türkiye's more independent geopolitical positioning can be traced to the early 1960s. The

[5] See, for instance, Oğuzlu 2023 and Gulmez 2020.

Cuban Missile Crisis made the Turkish government particularly concerned about relying unconditionally on the American defence system, as well as about the possibility of being used as a bargaining chip by the USA.[6] However, the HI show that Türkiye's diplomatic divergence from the United States, accompanied by a relative rapprochement with the USSR, was rather short-lived and lasted for approximately one decade.

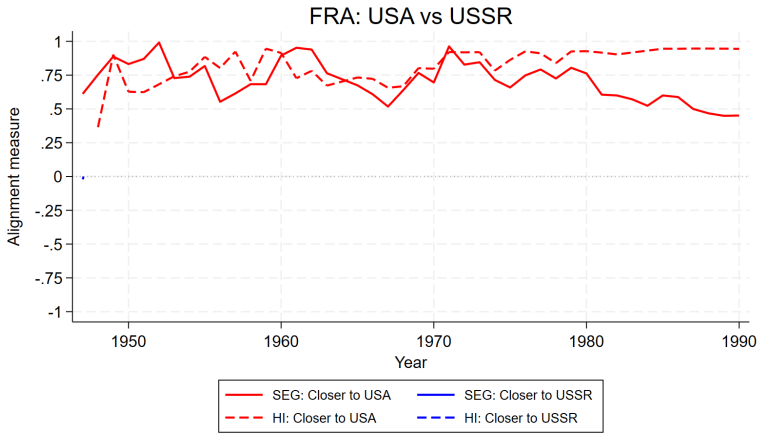


Figure 2: France: HI vs SEG during the Cold War.

France and the USA have been close allies since the American War of Independence. Nevertheless, their diplomatic relations have been characterised by diverging perspectives on several issues, including the role of NATO in Europe, the Vietnam War and the Suez Crisis.[7] These fluctuations in diplomatic alignment, and the subsequent rapprochement, are more clearly captured by the HI than by the conventional Alignment Index.

[6] See Hale 2012, page 110.
[7] See Statler 2016.

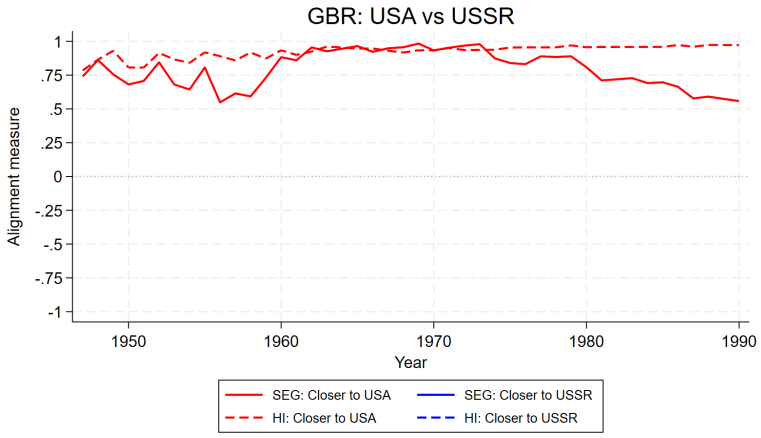


Figure 3: United Kingdom: HI vs SEG during the Cold War.

The United Kingdom and the USA diverged considerably in their UNGA voting patterns until the end of the 1950s. Meanwhile, Great Britain never substantially moved closer to the USSR, with the notable exception of 1950. While the Alignment Index suggests a gradual shift towards the USSR during the second half of the Cold War, the HI tell a different story. Particularly from 1960 onwards, the United Kingdom consistently ranked among the countries most closely aligned with the USA and most distant from the USSR.

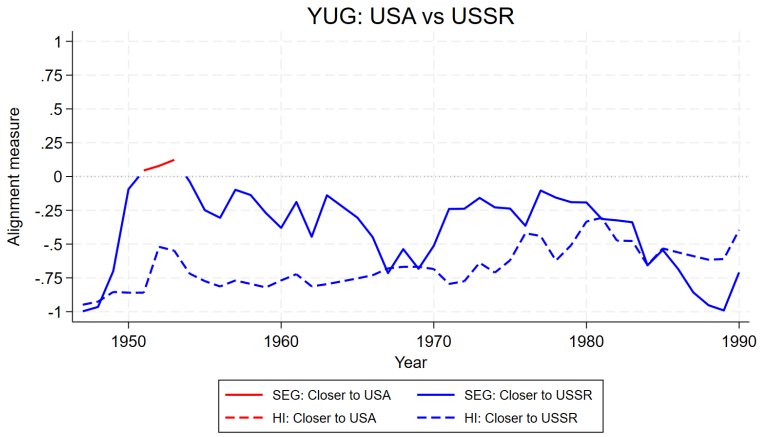
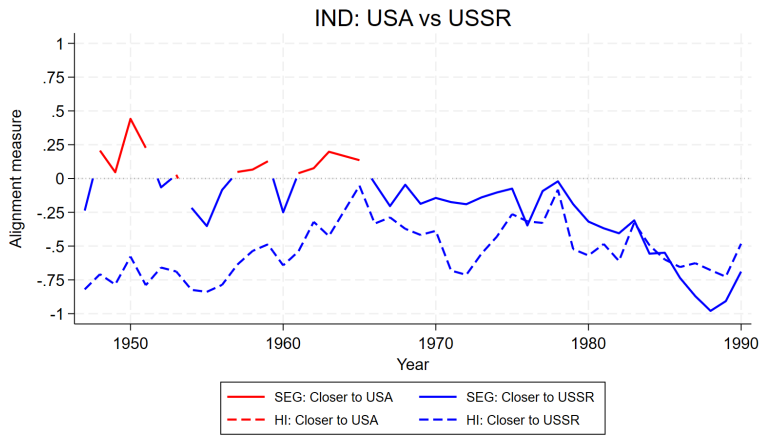


Figure 4: Yugoslavia: HI vs SEG during the Cold War.

Yugoslavia was a founding member of the Non-Aligned Movement. Despite its socialist institutional setting, it sought to detach itself from the direct in-

fluence of the USSR. The Alignment Index time series suggests a degree of geopolitical proximity to both superpowers. However, the HI reveal that Yugoslavia consistently voted relatively close to the USSR and far from the USA throughout the Cold War.



India was the largest country among the members of the Non-Aligned Movement. It never formally aligned itself with either the USA or the USSR. According to the Alignment Index, the former British colony remained roughly equidistant from the two superpowers. However, the HI reveal that India consistently voted closer to the USSR than to the USA. This suggests a less neutral diplomatic position than the one inferred from the Alignment Index and commonly discussed in the literature.[8]

4.1.2 China–USA Rivalry

The rise of China has increasingly challenged the USA's hegemonic position, marking a shift in the international order following the end of the Cold War.[9] The emergence of two competing centres of geopolitical influence has led countries to reconsider their international positioning, in some respects resembling the dynamics of the Cold War, albeit in a substantially different economic and institutional context.[10]

Examining countries' relative alignment with the USA and China therefore provides a useful opportunity to assess the informational content of the proposed HI relative to the conventional Alignment Index.

[8] See Pant and Super 2015.
[9] See Broner, Martin, Meyer, Trebesch, and Zhou Wu 2025.
[10] See Brands and Gaddis 2021.

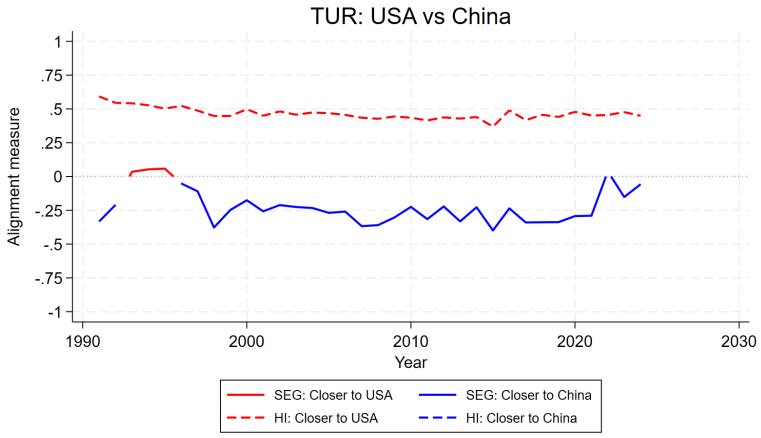


Figure 5: Türkiye: HI vs SEG during the USA–China rivalry.

The Alignment Index might suggest that Türkiye has increasingly aligned itself with China. The HI, however, reveal a different picture: Türkiye's voting patterns have remained consistently closer to those of the USA.

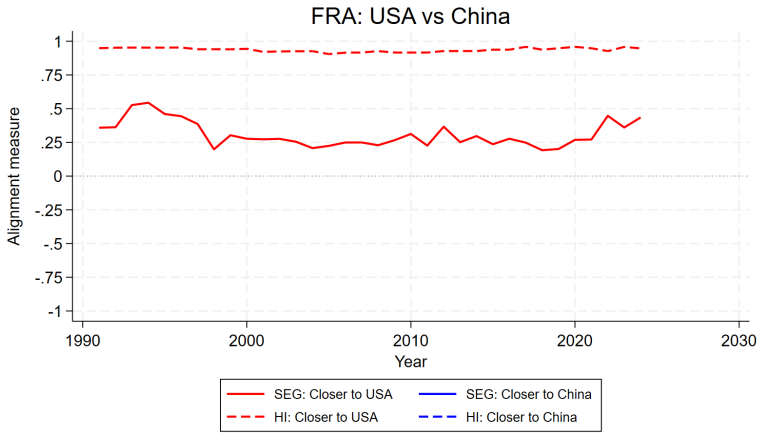


Figure 6: France: HI vs SEG during the USA–China rivalry.

In the post-Cold War period, France has remained a close ally of the USA. The HI capture this pattern clearly, showing France's relative proximity to the American position throughout the period.

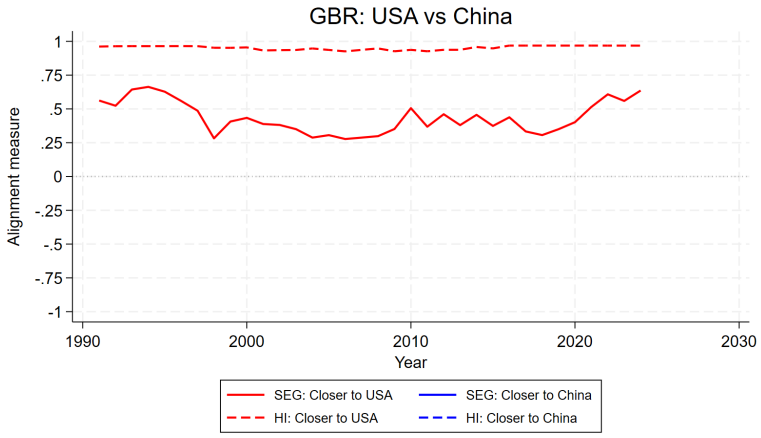


Figure 7: United Kingdom: HI vs SEG during the USA–China rivalry.

Similarly to France, the United Kingdom has remained closely aligned with the USA in its UNGA voting behaviour. The HI make this relative positioning particularly clear.

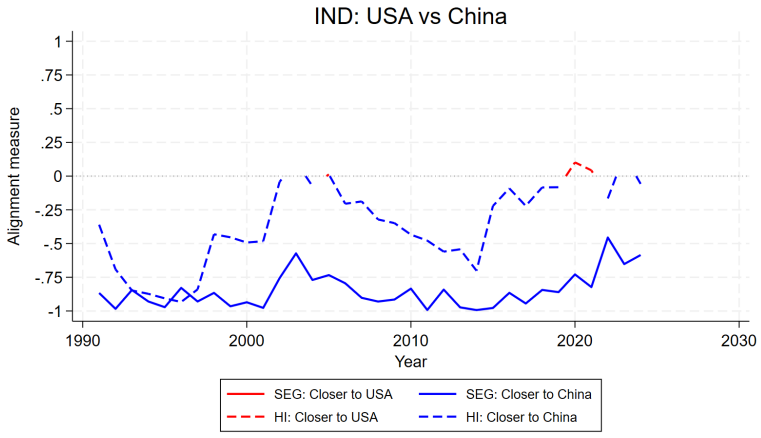


Figure 8: India: HI vs SEG during the USA–China rivalry.

India's non-alignment continued well beyond the end of the Cold War. Nevertheless, its voting behaviour reveals a closer relative alignment with China than with the USA for much of the period, although this pattern has changed in more recent years. The complex dynamics of India's diplomatic positioning are not adequately captured by the conventional Alignment Index, whereas the HI provide a clearer picture of its relative position within the international

distribution of UNGA voting patterns.

4.2 Geoeconomic Vulnerability: A New Perspective

4.2.1 Recomputing GeoV

One of the most relevant relationships under scrutiny in Geoeconomics is that between trade flows and geopolitical distance. Aiyar and Ohnsorge 2024, for example, follow a straightforward intuition: the more ideologically distant is a country from trading partners, the more vulnerable it will be to geopolitical tensions. They therefore propose to measure Geconomic Vulnerability as a weighted average of a country i Ideal Point Distances, where weights are determined by i exports/imports. Employing directly IPD is, as discussed in Section 4, subject to several drawbacks: being an a-dimensional measure, it is hard to compare across time and countries.AP_{ijt} can be thus used to rewrite[11]

$$AP_GeoV_{it} = \sum_{j \in J} \frac{y_{ij}}{\sum_j y_{ij}} * (1 - AP_{ijt}),$$

where y_{ij} is a trade flow from origin i to destination j (or viceversa). An intresting feature of AP_{ijt} is that it is nonsymmetric, unlike IPD_{ijt}. A possible interpretation follows: AP_{ijt} measure of how country i is ranked ideologically for $j \neq i$, therefore being interpretable as an *inward* measure, while AP_{jit} measures i's ranking of the other countries and thus can be interpreted as an *outward* measure. Given this distinction, AP_GeoV_{it} can actually be calculated as follows:

- With export weights and inward ranking:

$$XIAP\text{-}GeoV_{it} = \sum_{j \in J} \frac{x_{ijt}}{\sum_j x_{ijt}} (1 - AP_{jit})$$

- With export weights and outward ranking:

$$XOAP\text{-}GeoV_{it} = \sum_{j \in J} \frac{x_{ijt}}{\sum_j x_{ijt}} (1 - AP_{ijt})$$

- With import weights and inward ranking:

$$MIAP\text{-}GeoV_{it} = \sum_{j \in J} \frac{m_{ijt}}{\sum_j m_{ijt}} (1 - AP_{jit})$$

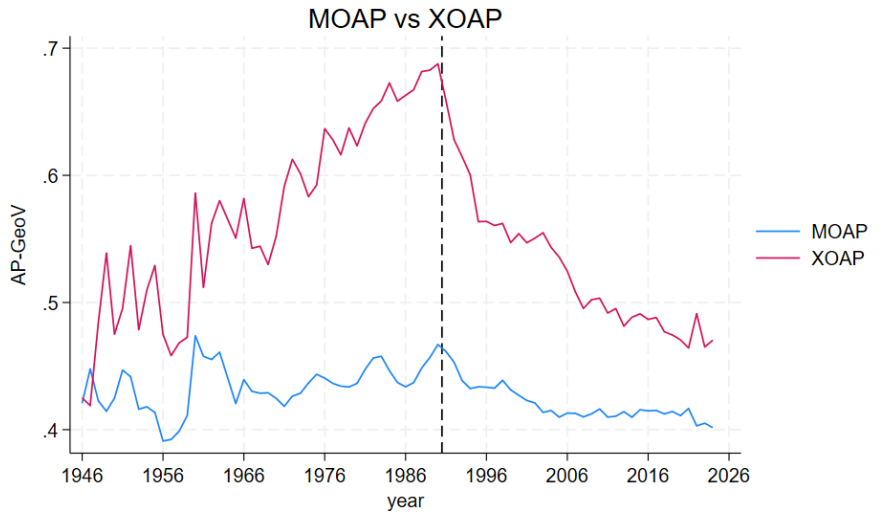
- With import weights and outward ranking:

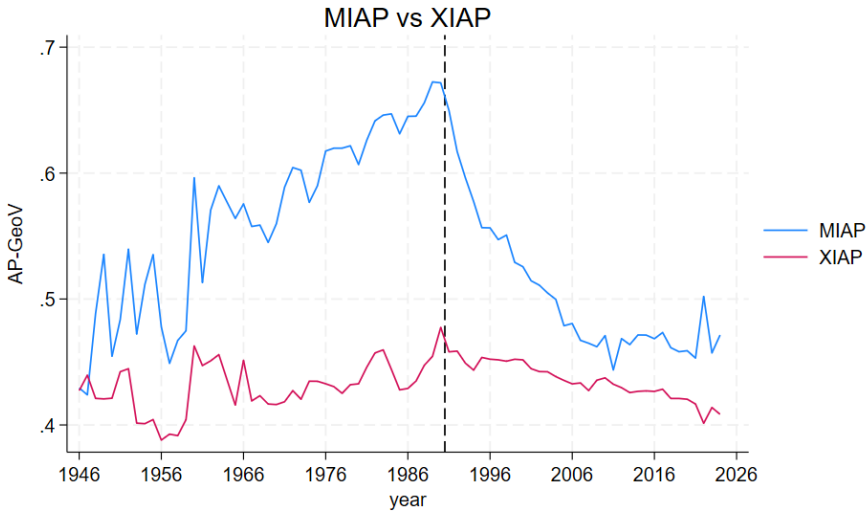
$$MOAP\text{-}GeoV_{it} = \sum_{j \in J} \frac{m_{ijt}}{\sum_j m_{ijt}} (1 - AP_{ijt})$$

[11] I take the inverse of the Agreement Percentiles to allow for the analogy with IPD.

We can therefore exploit the nonsymmetric nature of ranking percentiles in order to understand two different dimensions of geopolitical risk: one related to a country's ideological preferences regarding its trading partners and the other one concerning the trading partners' ideological preferences of a country.

4.2.2 Aggregate Analysis





MOAP presents a rather stable time series, with a slight decline starting from the end of the Cold War. In other words, it look like the average country's importers are perceived relatively close over time. On the other hand, the end of Cold War marks a steep decline in XOAP, which tells how far, in terms of ranking percentile, a country's export destinations are from origin. A possible explanation for this figure is the ideological rapprochement to the West by countries that were formerly part of the Soviet Bloc, together with the associated outflow of exports from West to East.[12] This hypothesis is reinforced by the MIAP time series as well, telling how far a country is from its average import suppliers.

The West is systematically less vulnerable geoeconomically than we tend to perceive. This has been consistently the case.

4.3 The Gravity of Reciprocity

4.3.1 Specification

An important topic in Geoeconomics is understanding whether geopolitical alignment influences trade. However, there has been no focus on udnerstanding the impact of geopolitical reciprocity on international trade. I propose to apply the gravity framework to exploit the non symmtric nature of AP. I therefore construct the following measure:

$$R_{ij} = \frac{AP_{ij} - AP_{ji}}{AP_{ij} + AP_{ji}} \tag{2}$$

R_{ij} is bounded in $[-1; 1]$ and provides information on whether the country pair ij entertains a geopolitically balanced relationship. If $R_{ij} > 0$ (resp. < 0), then j is relatively closer (resp. further) to (from) i than i is to (from) j. I run the following Pseudo Poisson Maximum Likelihood (henceforth PPML) regression:

$$y_{ijt} = exp(\beta_1 R_{ijt} + \beta_2 R_{ijt}^2 + \gamma_{it} + \delta_{jt} + \eta_{ij}) + \varepsilon_{ijt}, \tag{3}$$

where y_{ijt} is a trade flow from i to j at time t, γ_{it}, δ_{jt} and η_{ij} are fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered by ij pairs. The choice of a quadratic form for R_{ij} fits the way this reciprocity measure is constructed. That is, I expect that too extreme values of R_{ij} have symmetric effects on trade.

[12] See, for example, Aslund 2012.

4.3.2 Results

Table 1: PPML Estimates on Trade Flows: R_{ij}

	1948-1991	1992-2001	2002-2024
R_{ij}	0.038	-0.056**	0.019
	(0.035)	(0.023)	(0.014)
R_{ij}^2	-0.061	-0.261***	0.063***
	(0.048)	(0.046)	(0.018)
Observations		1,181,181	
Origin × Year FE		Yes	
Destination × Year FE		Yes	
Origin–Destination Pair FE		Yes	
Clusters		32,617	
Pseudo R^2		0.990	

Standard errors clustered by origin–destination pair in parentheses.
*** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

Table 2: PPML Estimates on Trade Flows: R_{ij}

	1948-1991	1992-2001	2002-2008	2009-2021	2022-2024
R_{ij}	0.037	-0.057**	-0.042**	0.033**	0.060
	(0.035)	(0.023)	(0.020)	(0.017)	(0.045)
$R_{ij}'^2$	-0.061	-0.261***	-0.146***	0.048***	0.429***
	(0.048)	(0.047)	(0.031)	(0.018)	(0.084)
Observations			1,181,181		
Origin × Year FE			Yes		
Destination × Year FE			Yes		
Origin–Destination Pair FE			Yes		
Clusters			32,617		
Pseudo R^2			0.990		

Standard errors clustered by origin–destination pair in parentheses.
*** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

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